Arthasastra

Arthasastra, the classic work on economy and statecraft authored by Kautilya during the Mauryan period, refers to Pandya kavataka. It may mean the pearl and shells from the Pandyan country.

Mahavamsa

Mahavamsa, the Sri Lankan Buddhist **chronicle**, composed in the Pali language, mentions merchants and horse traders from Tamil Nadu and South India.

Chronicle is a narrative text presenting the important historical events in chronological order.

Periplus of Erythrean Sea

Periplus of Erythrean Sea is an ancient Greek text whose author is not known. The term Periplus means navigational guide used by sailors. Erythrean Sea refers to the waters around the Red Sea. It makes references to the Sangam Age ports of Muciri, Thondi, Korkai and Kumari, as well as the Cheras and the Pandyas.

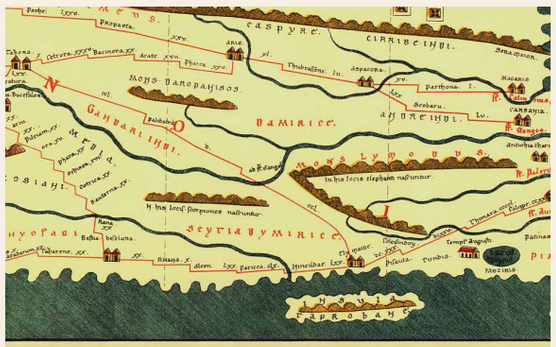
Pliny's Natural History

Pliny the Elder, was a Roman who wrote *Natural History*. Written in Latin, it is a text on the natural wealth of the Roman Empire. Pliny speaks about the pepper trade with India . He states that it took 40 days to reach India, from Ocealis near North East Africa, if the south west monsoon wind was favourable. He also mentions that the Pandyas of Madurai controlled the port of Bacare on the Kerala coast. The current name of Bacare is not known. Pliny laments the loss of Roman wealth due to Rome's pepper trade with India indication of the huge volume useful of the pepper that was traded.

Ptolemy's Geography

Ptolemy's *Geography* is a gazetteer and atlas of Roman times providing geographical details of the Roman Empire in the second century AD (CE). Kaveripoompattinam (Khaberis Emporium), Korkai (Kolkoi), Kanniyakumari (Komaria), and Muciri (Muziris) are some of the places mentioned in his *Geography*.

Peutingerian table



Map of Peutingerian table

Peutingerian table is an illustrated map of the Roman roads. It shows the areas of ancient Tamilagam and the port of Muziris.

***Note*:** Taprobane refers to Sri Lanka as Island. Muziris refers to the port of Muchiri.

Vienna Papyrus

Vienna **papyrus**, a Greek document datable to the second century AD (CE), mentions Muciri's trade of olden days. It is in the Papyrus Museum attached to the Austrian National Library, Vienna (Austria). It contains a written agreement between traders and mentions the name of a ship, Hermapollon, and lists articles of export such as pepper and ivory that were shipped from India to the Roman Empire.

Papyrus, a paper produced out of the papyrus plant used extensively for writing purposes in ancient Egypt.

3.2 The Sangam Age

The Sangam Age or the Early Historic period is an important phase in the history of South India. This period is marked out from prehistory, because of the availability of textual sources, namely Sangam literature and Tamil-Brahmi inscriptions. Sangam text is a vast corpus of literature that serves as an important source for the study of the people and society of the relevant period.

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